

Knotty no more: Demystifying test and learn

A practical workshop to build your understanding and confidence in test and learn.



WHAT IS TEST & LEARN?

Test and learn is a way of working that uses iterative design, testing, and adaptation to improve how policies and services are developed and delivered in situations with lots of uncertainty and complexity.

It looks like 🙌



Lead with context not control - A new way to lead.

Focus on the outcome to achieve with clear boundaries and flexibilities, rather than a rigid plan.



Make contact with reality - A new place to start.

Get into the field and involve the people closest to the problem in development.



Test assumptions first - A new way to handle risk.

Identify your riskiest assumptions early, then test them simply and quickly.



Work in learning loops - A new way to make progress.

Work in short cycles that include regular real-world feedback and adaptation.

PART 1: PICK AN OUTCOME BASED GOAL



Find a partner or two, then pick one of the below challenges to work on together.

Select one

Childcare cold spot

In a deprived ward, take-up of the funded 2-year-old childcare places is stuck around 50%. We're launching **personal sign-up phone calls to walk every eligible family through registering**. Target: 50% to 90% in a year.

What we know

- 15 funded hours/week for eligible 2-year-olds; aimed at most disadvantaged.
- Quality of childcare provision matters.

Open questions

- What's actually stopping the other 50%?
- What's the best way to reach those who'd benefit most?
- What effect will the phone calls have?



Weight-loss drugs

The local NHS is piloting free weight-loss drugs (GLP-1s) for 2,000 people with obesity. You are designing the **wraparound support so the weight actually stays off**. Target: sustained weight loss two years on.

What we know

- ~2 in 3 adult live with excess weight.
- GLP-1's produce real weight loss while people take them.

Open questions

- How should the wraparound support work?
- What will help people build sustainable habits?
- How much will it cost?



Heat pumps for tenants

To meet the 2030 EPC C standard, we're **offering landlords a £7,500 grant to swap gas boilers for heat pumps** in rented homes. Target: 1,000 installs in year one.

What we know

- The landlord pays; the tenant gets the warmth and lower bills.
- Rented housing stock is older, smaller and less efficient than average.

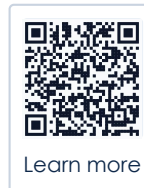
Open questions

- Why would a landlord actually do this?
- What would make a tenant say yes?
- What's the real barrier here - and for whom?



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PART 2: IDENTIFY YOUR RISKIEST ASSUMPTIONS



In groups, each write and share some key assumptions. Then **pick one** that most needs to be true - the riskiest that would upend your proposed path forward - this will then be the one you speed test.

What do we need to learn or demonstrate next?

PART 3: DEFINE A SPEED TEST



In groups, come up with a plan for how you could simply, quickly, and safely test your riskiest assumption.

Which test and learn methods would help you test your riskiest assumption

Pick from the methods cards on the next page.

How could you practically run the speed test next week - for under £100, or by testing with 5 people?

Describe or sketch the steps in your speed test.

What are your indicators of success or failure for this speed test?

What do you need to see from this test to help you decide whether to pivot, ditch, or commit?

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Learn more

ANNEX 1: RAPID TEST & LEARN METHODS

Stakeholder value

Are people's needs, behaviours and context met?

Observation

Follow the real experience and take rich notes of what goes on.

Good for real behaviour, not what people claim.

Try: spend a few hours in the field or shadow a colleague.

Interviews

Grab 5–6 people where they already are and ask about their needs.

Good for honest insight fast.

Try: 20 mins at the front line, ask what stops them.

Concierge

Deliver the value by hand behind the scenes so it feels real.

Good for testing the offer actually helps before building it.

Try: fake the "smart" part for a few people.

Impact

How big is the likely benefit — and is it caused by us?

Theory of change sketch

Map how activities lead to outcomes on one page.

Good for making the causal logic — and its assumptions — explicit.

Try: 30 mins — "if X → Y → outcome, because Z".

Leading indicators

Pick an early signal that signals your ultimate outcome.

Good for seeing impact in days, not years.

Try: track steps in the process not just the destination.

Single case before/after

Measure one person or site just before and just after.

Good for a first, honest signal of change.

Try: rate confidence 1–10 before and after one session.

Viability

Is it economically viable and sustainable over time?

Rough cost model

Roughly estimate cost per person or per outcome on one sheet.

Good for a first read on whether the sums could ever add up.

Try: unit cost × expected numbers vs the alternative.

Willingness to commit test

Ask for money, time or a deposit — not just a "yes".

Good for separating real intent from polite interest.

Try: ask 10 people or a funder to pre-commit; count who does.

Fake door test

Advertise the offer that doesn't exist yet; count who tries it.

Good for real demand before you spend on delivery.

Try: an expression of interest form and count sign ups.

Feasibility

Is it deliverable and technically possible?

Roleplay

Rehearse the full process once, end to end, as a team.

Good for finding what breaks in practice.

Try: roleplay one live case start to finish.

Proof of concept spike

Build only the single riskiest technical bit, quickly.

Good for checking the hard part is possible before committing.

Try: one day on the feature you're least sure about.

Concierge

Deliver the whole thing by hand for a few users.

Good for learning what delivery really takes.

Try: serve 3 people end-to-end; log every friction.

Political acceptability

Will the public, media and decision-makers accept it?

Hostile headline test

Write the worst news headline about your idea.

Good for surfacing reputational and political risk early.

Try: 20 mins — draft the attack, then your response.

Vox pop reaction

Show a plain description/sketch; capture people's gut reactions.

Good for gauging acceptability and spotting red flags.

Try: 8 quick reactions online or on the street.

A/B message test

Run two framings of the same offer; see which lands.

Good for testing language and framing more robustly.

Try: two versions to 50 people each; compare response.

Scalability

What is the potential for impact beyond one place?

Map bottlenecks

Map out what breaks first if demand is multiplied.

Good for spotting the constraint that caps scale.

Try: map the step that jams at 10× today's numbers.

Demand test at volume

A landing page or sign-up shared widely to gauge reach.

Good for seeing whether interest exists at scale.

Try: share one page in several groups; count sign-ups.

Next site replication

Run the same test in a contrasting place or group.

Good for checking it isn't a one-off before scaling.

Try: repeat your test with one different community.

Unintended consequences

How might we cause harm — and how do we avoid it?

Compared to what

Name what would happen anyway, including who loses out.

Good for honest attribution and spotting displacement.

Try: 15 mins — "what happens without us, and to whom?"

Pre-mortem

Imagine it's six months on and it failed; work back to why.

Good for surfacing hidden risks fast.

Try: 20 mins — "it flopped. Here's why..."

Consequence scanning

Ask "who could this harm, and how?" with a mixed group.

Good for catching unintended harms before they happen.

Try: list wanted/unwanted, intended/unintended effects.

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